

| By Uday Mahurkar |

In the late 1990s, when a group of locals found ancient cattle bones near Khirsara village in a sunken and not-so-arid part of western Kutch, Gujarat, they smelled easy money in selling them or using them for industrial purposes. Little did they know that a decade later, the site from where they were lifting the bones would become the focus of archaeologists studying the mystical antiquity of the Indus Valley or the Harappan civilisation. That ancient civilisation is intrinsically linked to the past of the sub-continent, evident in the form of over 1,600 Harappan sites across the region topped by Mohenjodaro and Harappa in Pakistan, and Dholavira and Kalibangan in India. Ongoing excavations in the outskirts of Khirsara since January last year by a team of the Vadodra circle of the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) have revealed what is virtually a veritable goldmine of Harappan remains. In the form of a well-fortified settlement spread over 75,000 sq m, complete with properly demarcated residential and business zones, the site has been revealed to be a major trade centre during the Harappan period on the trade route from Gujarat-Saurashtra to the Harappan settlements in lower Sindh areas such as Balakot and Amari.

In fact, many sites have been discovered in eastern Kutch—the last being the famous Dholavira—but Khirsara is the biggest settlement to have been found so far in western Kutch. Apart from that, half a dozen smaller sites have also been found in the past within a radius of 15 km of Khirsara, such as Deshalpur-Gunthli. During initial exploration, Khirsara revealed all the features of a standard Harappan settlement with archaeologists recovering artifacts like beads, stone blades, drill bits, different types of pottery, pieces of the standard Harappan seal, bone tools and a fortified wall. Says ASI's Superintending Archaeologist Jitendra Nath, who is



The excavation of yet another Harappan site in Gujarat reveals a large, fortified settlement that may have been a major trading centre for animals apart from the usual products



Bones of CIVILIS

excavating the site along with archaeologist R.N. Kumaran, "It appears that Khirsara was an important trade centre located on the all important trade routes from Gujarat to lower Sindh and things like shell bangles, beads made of semi-precious stones and steatite beads were manufactured here and exported to lower Sindh." The ASI team, comprising about 100 people, including technical

hands, plans to continue excavations for two more seasons to get more clues. The aim is to study the subsistence pattern at Khirsara during the Harappan period and establish its context with other such sites.

What distinguishes Khirsara from the other sites is the fact that a very large number of cattle bones as well as that of wild animals have been recovered. Archaeologists believe



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JITENDRA NATH, *Superintending Archaeologist, ASI*